SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #29 · JOB LOSS AND SETBACKS

“I should be further along by now.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Comparison is a quiet thief. Classmates’ promotions, social media updates, a parent’s expectations, or an internal timeline we set long ago can make us feel behind. Setbacks, caregiving, health, or career changes can slow us down, yet we measure ourselves against a straight line that few people actually walk.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says that to everything there is a season and a time for every purpose under heaven. David prays, “My times are in Your hands.” Paul wrote, “Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize of God’s heavenly calling in Christ Jesus.” He also says that He who began a good work in us will carry it on to completion. God works on His own timetable, and the Bible’s heroes, from Moses to Joseph, often seemed far behind before God moved. Being “behind” is a measurement by the wrong ruler.

> *“Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize of God’s heavenly calling in Christ Jesus”* (Philippians 3:13–14).

Also see

> “To everything there is a season, and a time for every purpose under heaven” (Ecclesiastes 3:1).

> “My times are in Your hands; deliver me from my enemies and from those who pursue me” (Psalm 31:15).

> “For the vision awaits an appointed time; it testifies of the end and does not lie. Though it lingers, wait for it, since it will surely come and will not delay” (Habakkuk 2:3).

> “Being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus” (Philippians 1:6).

Common self-statements

- Everyone my age is ahead of me.
- I have wasted so much time.
- I should have achieved more by now.
- It is too late to catch up.
- I am behind in every area.
- I will never reach where others are.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should be at a certain place by a certain age.
- Social comparison: Measuring my life against other people’s highlights.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I am either on schedule or a failure.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking what I have accomplished.

Challenging questions

- Who set the timeline I am measuring myself against?
- What have I accomplished and learned in the years I think were “wasted”?
- Whose path am I comparing myself to, and what do I not know about it?
- What does God’s timing look like in the lives of people in Scripture?
- What season am I in right now?
- What is one step forward I can take?

Truth summary

> My times are in God’s hands. The timeline I am measuring against is not His. I can look at where I have been, receive where I am, and press on toward what is ahead without condemning myself for the pace.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Plans
- Trust
- Thankful
- Dissatisfaction
- Will of God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Trouble/Hardship

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Do It Again — Steven Curtis Chapman
God’s repeated gifts and new mercies express His continuing love.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ’s resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Already There — Casting Crowns
God’s perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God’s steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I should be further along by now"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I should be further along by now." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who set my timeline?
- ☐ What have I learned in these years?
- ☐ Whose life am I comparing mine to?
- ☐ What season am I in?
- ☐ What can I thank God for?
- ☐ What is one step this month?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My times are in God's hands.
- ☐ There is a season for everything.
- ☐ Comparison is an unreliable ruler.
- ☐ I have grown more than I realize.
- ☐ God carries His work to completion.
- ☐ I can press on from here.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Philippians 3:13–14**
  "Brothers, I do not consider myself yet to have taken hold of it. But one thing I do: Forgetting what is behind and straining toward what is ahead, I press on toward the goal to win the prize of God's heavenly calling in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ **Ecclesiastes 3:1**
  "To everything there is a season, and a time for every purpose under heaven."
- ☐ **Psalm 31:15**
  "My times are in Your hands; deliver me from my enemies and from those who pursue me."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Where I am, not where I should be: Each week, write one thing you have learned or gained in this season and one step you took.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Philippians 3:13–14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "My times are in God's hands, so I can press on from where I am.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Plans" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Name the timeline. Write where you thought you should be and who or what set that target.
- [ ] Write your growth list. List what you have learned or become in the last five years.
- [ ] Limit comparisons. Take a break from checking others' updates for a week.
- [ ] Choose a next step. Decide on one forward move this month.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I should be further along by now": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Progress noticed
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I should be further along by now.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, my times are in Your hands. Forgive me for measuring myself by a timeline You did not give. Help me press on from where I am with thankfulness and trust. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.